Bishop's Opening

ECO C23-C43 | 41 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.c3 d5 4.Bxd5 Nf6

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **-0.10** (equal, depth 18). Best: d4.

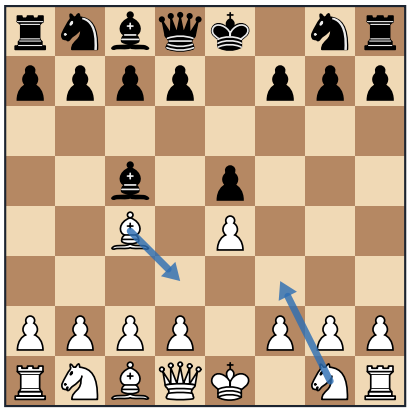
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.c3 d5 4.Bxd5 Nf6

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Bc4	Aim at f7. Develops the bishop to c4.
2... Bc5	Active bishop. Develops the bishop to c5.
3. c3	Prepare d4. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3... d5	Free the position. Occupies the center with a pawn.
4. Bxd5	Captures on d5 to trade or win material.
4... Nf6	Counter e4. Develops the knight to f6.



After 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

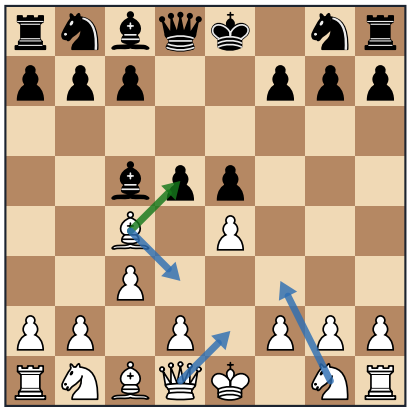


Position after the line

McDonnell Gambit C23 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.b4`

Stockfish: **-0.26** (slightly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: Bxb4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: La Bourdonnais-Denker Gambit, McDonnell Double Gambit

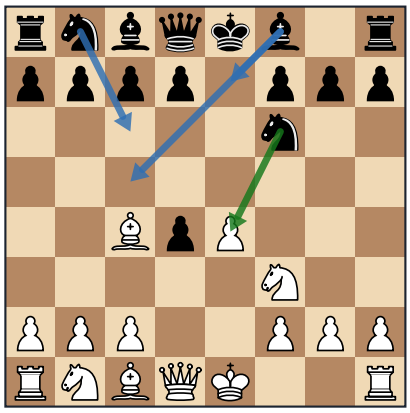


Position after the line

Lewis Countergambit C23 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.c3 d5`

Stockfish: **-0.09** (equal, depth 19). Best next move: Bxd5.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Walker Variation

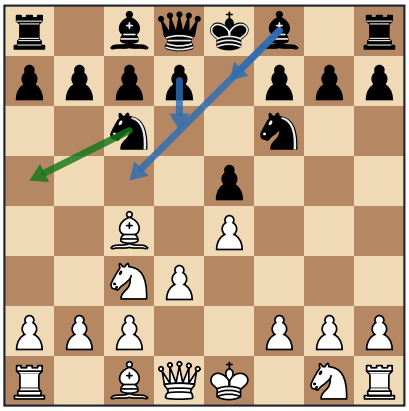


Position after the line

Urusov Gambit C43 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nf3`

Stockfish: **-0.44** (slightly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Panov Variation, Keidansky Gambit

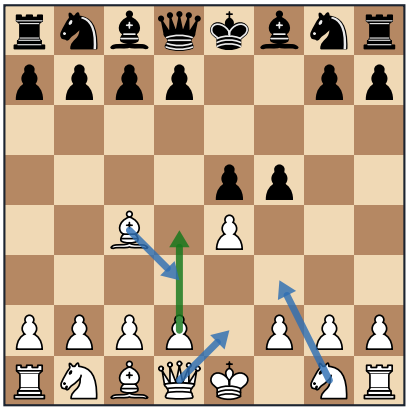


Position after the line

Vienna Hybrid C24 | 3 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6 3.d3 Nc6 4.Nc3`

Stockfish: **+0.00** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: Na5.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Spielmann Attack, Hromádka Variation

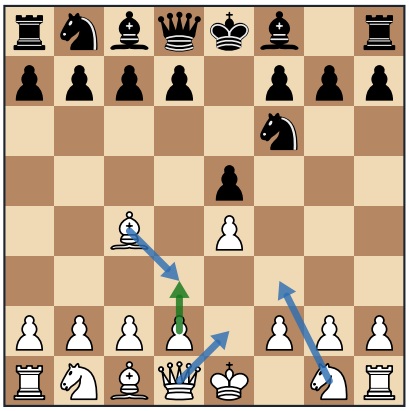


Position after the line

Calabrese Countergambit C23 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 f5`

Stockfish: **+1.02** (clearly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Jaenisch Variation



Position after the line

Berlin Defense C24 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+0.10** (equal, depth 18). Best next move: d3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Greco Gambit

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Bishop's Opening (all lines)** — C23
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4`
  - **Berlin Defense** — C24
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6`
    - **Greco Gambit** — C24
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6 -> 3.f4`
  - **Boi Variation** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5`
  - **Calabrese Countergambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...f5`
    - **Jaenisch Variation** — C23
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 f5 -> 3.d3`
  - **Khan Gambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...d5`
  - **Philidor Counterattack** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...c6`
  - **Lewis Gambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.d4`
  - **Lopez Variation** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.Qe2`
    - **Lopez Gambit** — C23
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.Qe2 -> 3...Nf6 4.f4`
  - **McDonnell Gambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.b4`
    - **La Bourdonnais-Denker Gambit** — C23
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.b4 -> 3...Bxb4 4.c3`
    - **McDonnell Double Gambit** — C23
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.b4 -> 3...Bxb4 4.f4`
  - **Philidor Variation** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.c3`
  - **Ponziani Gambit** — C24
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.d4`
  - **Stein Gambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.f4`
  - **Anderssen Gambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...b5 3.Bxb5 c6`
  - **Horwitz Gambit** — C26
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.Nc3 b5`
  - **Lewis Countergambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.c3 d5`
    - **Walker Variation** — C23
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.c3 d5 -> 4.Bxd5 Nf6 5.d4`
  - **Paulsen Defense** — C24
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.d3 c6`
  - **Thorold Gambit** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...b5 3.Bxb5 f5`
  - **del Rio Variation** — C23
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.c3 Qg5`
  - **Boden-Kieseritzky Gambit** — C27
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bc4 Nxe4 4.Nc3`
    - **Lichtenhein Defense** — C27
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bc4 Nxe4 4.Nc3 -> 4...d5`
  - **Pachman Gambit** — C24
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.Ne2 Nxe4 4.Nec3`
  - **Urusov Gambit** — C43
    `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nf3`
    - **Keidansky Gambit** — C43
      `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nf3 -> 4...Nxe4 5.Qxd4`

- **Panov Variation** C24
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nf6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nf3 -> 4...d5 5.exd5 Bb4 6.c3 Qe7`
- **Vienna Hybrid** C24
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.d3 Nc6 4.Nc3`
  - **Spielmann Attack** C26
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.Bc4 Bc5 4.d3`
  - **Hromádka Variation** C28
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nc3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.d3 Bb4 5.Ne2`
- **Warsaw Gambit** C24
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.d4 exd4 4.c3`
- **Kitchener Folly** C24
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.d3 Be7 4.Nf3 O-O`
- **Krejcik Gambit** C24
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Nf6 3.f3 Bc5 4.Ne2 Nc6 5.b4`
- **Lopez Gambit** C23
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.Qe2 Nc6 4.c3 Nf6 5.f4`
- **Pratt Variation** C23
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.c3 Nf6 4.d4 exd4 5.e5 d5 6.exf6 dxc4 7.Qh5 O-O`
- **Lisitsyn Variation** C23
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...c6 3.d4 d5 4.exd5 cxd5 5.Bb5 Bd7 6.Bxd7 Nxd7 7.dxe5 Nxe5 8.Ne2`
- **Four Pawns Gambit** C23
  `1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 -> 2...Bc5 3.b4 Bxb4 4.f4 exf4 5.Nf3 Be7 6.d4 Bh4 7.g3 fxg3 8.O-O gxh2 9.Kh1`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.c3 d5 4.Bxd5 Nf6
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Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.